

Word family: **symbol / symbols / symbolic / symbolically / symbolism / symbolize / symbolise**

Base word: symbol

Plural: symbols

Related forms: symbolic, symbolically, symbolism, symbolize / symbolise

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / related adjective, adverb and verb forms (相關形容詞、副詞及動詞)

Your sentence:

> “It was like seeing a living **symbol** of patience and balance.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **symbol** means a **person, animal, object, or image that represents a broader quality or idea**.

The turtle did not literally *equal* patience and balance. Its calm, graceful behaviour made it **represent** those qualities in the speaker’s mind.

繁體中文：** **能代表、體現或令人聯想到某種抽象概念、價值或特質的人、動物、物件或形象；象徵**

中文翻譯：

> “It was like seeing a living **symbol** of patience and balance.”

「那感覺就像看到一個耐性與平衡的活生生**象徵**。」

1. **symbol = thing that represents an idea/quality (象徵) — 象徵；代表**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: A person, object, image, animal, action, etc. that represents or stands for a broader abstract idea or quality.

Practice 1 — Original

> “The turtle seemed like a living **symbol** of patience and balance.”

「那隻海龜就像耐性和平衡的活生生**象徵**。」

Practice 2

> “The dove is commonly used as a **symbol** of peace.”

「白鴿常被用作和平的**象徵**。」

Practice 3

> “The building became a **symbol** of the city’s renewal.”

「那棟建築成為城市復興的**象徵**。」

symbol = 透過具體形象代表或體現另一個較抽象的概念、價值或特質

Common:

- * symbol of peace
- * symbol of hope
- * symbol of strength
- * national symbol
- * cultural symbol

2. **symbol** = written/sign mark representing information (符號) — 符號；標誌

A **symbol** can also be a mark, character, or sign that represents information, an operation, an object, or a concept.

Practice 4

> “The dollar **symbol** is \$.”

「美元**符號**是 \$。」

Practice 5

> “Use the correct mathematical **symbol**.”

「使用正確的數學**符號**。」

symbol = 用來代表某種資訊、概念、數值或操作的圖形 / 記號

Common:

- * mathematical symbol
- * currency symbol
- * warning symbol

* chemical symbol

This is genuinely distinct from the figurative “symbol of hope” sense, although both involve **representation**.

3. **symbol** = conventional sign in a specialized system (專業系統) — 符號 ; 代號

In science, mathematics, computing, music, etc., symbols can have precise conventional meanings.

Practice 6

> “H is the chemical **symbol** for hydrogen.”

「H 是氫的化學**符號**。」

Practice 7

> “The map uses different **symbols** for hospitals and stations.”

「地圖用不同的**符號**表示醫院和車站。」

symbol = 在某個正式符號系統中，按照共同規則代表特定內容的記號

For strict counting, I would merge this with Meaning 2. The domain changes, but the core idea remains:

> **a conventional sign that represents information**

4. **symbol** = emblem/identifying sign (標誌 / 徽號) — 標誌 ; 徽號

A **symbol** can identify a group, institution, movement, brand, culture, etc.

Practice 8

> “The flower is an important cultural **symbol**.”

「這種花是一個重要的文化**標誌 / 象徵**。」

Practice 9

> “The logo became a recognizable **symbol** of the organization.”

「那個標誌成為該組織容易辨認的**象徵 / 標誌**。」

This sits between the concrete-sign and figurative-representation senses.

For database counting, I would not split it further.

Related form: **symbolic**

Symbolic has two major useful branches.

**symbolic = representing a deeper idea (象徵性的) **

Practice 10

> “The journey has a **symbolic** meaning.”

「這段旅程具有**象徵性的**意義。」

Practice 11

> “The turtle became **symbolic** of patience.”

「那隻海龜成為耐性的**象徵**。」

symbolic = 並非只具有字面意義，而代表更深層的概念、價值或特質

**symbolic = mainly expressing meaning rather than having practical effect (象徵性的) **

Practice 12

> “The payment was largely **symbolic**.”

「那筆款項主要只是**象徵性的**。」

Practice 13

> “They made a **symbolic** gesture of support.”

「他們作出了一個**象徵性**的支持行動。」

Here:

****symbolic = 主要用來表達態度、意義或立場，而不是產生重大實際效果****

This is a very important extension of ****symbolic****.

Related form: ****symbolically****

Practice 14

> “The door ****symbolically**** represents a new beginning.”

「那扇門在****象徵意義上****代表新的開始。」

****symbolically = 以象徵方式；在象徵意義上****

Related form: ****symbolism****

****Symbolism**** has two useful meanings.

****symbolism = use of symbols (象徵手法) ****

Practice 15

> “The story contains a lot of ****symbolism****.”

「這個故事包含很多****象徵手法****。」

Practice 16

> “Water has important ****symbolism**** in the poem.”

「水在詩中具有重要的****象徵意義****。」

****symbolism = 透過人物、物件、顏色、動作等代表較深層概念的表達方法 / 象徵意義****

****Symbolism = artistic/literary movement (象徵主義) ****

Capitalized or in art/literature contexts, ****Symbolism**** can refer to a historical artistic/literary movement.

This is established but more specialized, so for a general learner database I would keep it as a lower-priority domain note rather than a core **symbol** meaning.

Related form: **symbolize / symbolise**

Symbolize means to be a symbol of, or represent, something abstract.

Practice 17

> “The tree **symbolizes** growth and renewal.”

「這棵樹**象徵**成長與新生。」

Practice 18

> “For him, the turtle **symbolized** patience.”

「對他來說，那隻海龜**象徵**耐性。」

symbolize = 作為某個概念、價值或特質的象徵 / 代表

Spelling:

* **symbolize** — common in American English

* **symbolise** — common in British English

Important distinction: **symbol vs sign**

sign

is broader and can indicate that something exists or is happening.

> dark clouds are a sign of rain

= 烏雲是下雨的跡象。

symbol

represents an idea by convention, culture, design, or interpretation.

> dove as a symbol of peace

= 白鴿象徵和平。

So:

****sign = 跡象 / 標誌****

****symbol = 象徵 / 代表符號****

There is overlap, but not identity.

Important distinction: ****symbol vs icon****

**symbol**

represents something else.

**icon**

can mean:

- * a graphical interface image;
- * a famous/admired representative figure;
- * a religious image.

An icon may function as a symbol, but ****icon**** has its own specialized meanings.

Important distinction: ****symbol vs logo****

**logo**

is a specific graphic design identifying a company, organization, or brand.

**symbol**

is much broader.

A logo can become:

> a symbol of a company

but not every symbol is a logo.

Important distinction: ****symbol vs metaphor****

****symbol****

is an object/image/figure that represents a deeper concept.

****metaphor****

is a language or conceptual device that describes one thing in terms of another.

For example:

> “The turtle is a symbol of patience.”

direct symbolic representation.

> “Patience is an anchor.”

metaphor.

They can overlap in literary analysis but are not the same thing.

Important distinction: ****symbol vs representation****

****representation****

is the very broad concept of something standing for or depicting something else.

****symbol****

usually suggests a recognized, meaningful, or interpretive relationship.

So:

> symbol

is a particular type of representation.

Important distinction: ****symbolic vs literal****

This is especially relevant to your passage.

****literal****

means according to the direct ordinary meaning.

****symbolic****

means representing something deeper or abstract.

The turtle is literally:

> an animal

but symbolically:

> patience and balance.

Countability note

****Symbol**** is countable:

> a symbol

> several symbols

****Symbolism****, however, is generally uncountable when referring to the use of symbolic meaning:

> “The novel contains rich symbolism.”

Not normally:

> “a symbolism”

in ordinary usage.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* ****symbol****

* ****symbols****

* ****symbolic****

* **symbolically**
* **symbolism**
* **symbolize / symbolise**

Useful constructions include:

* symbol of something
* cultural symbol
* mathematical symbol
* chemical symbol
* symbolic meaning
* symbolic gesture
* symbolize something
* literary symbolism

The Golden Manual asks us to include common domain uses and useful family forms, while merging contexts where the same underlying semantic idea — **something representing something else** — still applies.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning	
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symbol — abstract representation	透過人物、動物、物件或形象代表另一個較抽象的概念、價值或特質	
symbol — written/conventional sign	用來代表資訊、數值、概念、操作或對象的圖形 / 記號	
symbol — identifying emblem	用來代表或識別群體、機構、文化等的標誌；與 representation 義相關	
symbolic — representative	具有象徵意義、代表更深層概念的	
symbolic — mainly expressive	主要用來表達態度或意義，而實際效果有限的；象徵性的	
symbolize / symbolise	作為某個概念、價值或特質的象徵	
symbolism	運用具體事物表達深層概念的象徵手法 / 象徵意義	

For your original sentence

> “It was like seeing a living **symbol** of patience and balance.”

The exact meaning is:

symbol = 一個具體存在的人、動物或事物，能夠代表或體現某種抽象特質

So:

> **a living symbol of patience and balance**

= **耐性和平衡的活生生象徵**

The turtle did not literally *mean* patience. Its behaviour — slow, calm, balanced, graceful — made the speaker perceive those abstract qualities through it.

For your database, I would count **2 genuinely useful core meanings** for **symbol**:

1. **a person/object/image that represents an abstract idea, value, or quality**
2. **a conventional written/visual sign representing information or a specific concept**

I would merge **cultural emblems, logos used symbolically, scientific symbols, map symbols**, etc. into those two branches according to function, and keep **symbolic, symbolism, symbolize/symbolise** as family extensions rather than inflate the core count.